



Art,
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Maham
Zahid

#1 – On
Encountering

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On Encountering

by Maham Zahid

A language model has read more than you ever will. It has also never been in the room.

At some point in my degree, I was asked to stop thinking about an object and simply hold it. To disengage from the idea of it - whatever category, affectation, or association it was - and to just encounter the material itself. Objects, it turns out, have what German material culture theory calls *Eigensinn*: a stubbornness, a way of pushing back against the meanings we project onto them. It was an unusual exercise. It was also training in something no optimization process can replicate: the capacity to meet something on its own terms.

I am finishing a degree that sits at an awkward intersection. Too applied for pure academics, too theoretical for agencies, and sometimes too abstract altogether, dealing in concepts as ephemeral as humans themselves. It sits at the confluence of cultural theory, design thinking, and strategic communication. For a long time, I wasn't sure what to call what I was learning. I'm now fairly certain it's the thing everyone ought to be looking for.

A conversation I keep having in industry confirms part of it. The capacities that are hardest to source right now are not technical ones — they are judgment under genuine uncertainty, especially when it's ethical and value-based, and the ability to read people and shifting contexts without reducing them to a data set. Skills that take intention and grounded presence to cultivate.

Meeting something on its own terms, then, turns out to be its own discipline. There is an older strategic tradition that treats efficacy not as the successful imposition of a projected ideal outcome but as the art of reading what a situation is already becoming and moving with it (detailed by François Jullien in *A Treatise on Efficacy*). This is wayfinding rather

than planning. And it describes what good strategic instinct actually looks like when the map runs out.

But the terrain itself is never still. People, objects, capital, ideas are always in motion, and meaning transforms as it travels. This means being present with people and cultures as they actually are, to read a room without reducing it to a data set. Paying slow, non-extractive attention. You cannot model it from a distance. You have to be present in the current.

The third move is to step back and assess how contexts have been framed. What culture actually is, who defined it, for whom, and what the frame leaves out — information that might be a part of AI's training data, yet lacking the real-world context to interrogate and reframe it. In an age where narratives are generated at scale, the capacity to ask whose story this is and what it presupposes is not a critical theory exercise. It is the work.

This is, I'd argue, an inherently artistic epistemology. What artistic practice has always cultivated — attention to materials on their own terms, resistance to premature categorization, the willingness to be changed by an encounter — is precisely what becomes scarce in a world of generated output. The work of art is not the object produced. It is the quality of the encounters that produced it. That cannot be trained on.

There is a caveat. These capacities develop through encounter, through accumulated presence in enough situations to learn how to read them. Which makes how you learn to pay attention matter more now than it perhaps ever did, at exactly the moment junior roles that once developed that attention are quietly disappearing. None of this arrived as career preparation. It came as rigorous inquiry, sometimes opaque, occasionally maddening. But what it built, cumulatively, is a way of encountering things without immediately collapsing them into what you already know.

A language model has read more than you ever will. But you have read the room. You have held the object. You have sensed what a situation was becoming.

For now, that's not nothing.

Maham Zahid studies GWK (Gesellschafts- und Wirtschaftskommunikation) at the Universität der Künste Berlin, a degree at the intersection of cultural studies, strategic communication, and design thinking. The piece draws on François Jullien's comparative philosophy of efficacy and propensity, John Urry and Mimi Sheller's new mobilities paradigm, and the tradition of German material culture research. What connects these works is a shared understanding that the world is not static or calculable and that the capacity to encounter it with grounded presence is not only a human competency but an artistic one. As AI accelerates, these capacities are not rendered obsolete but made apparent. To encounter a situation, a person, an idea, a material on its own terms may be the most essentially human thing we do.